Kenya **Energy & Infrastructure** Sector Report 2026

Strategic Insights for Energy, Transport, and Infrastructure Investment in Kenya

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ENERGY & INFRASTRUCTURE INTELLIGENCE BRIEF

The Outlook's most favourable external assumption was $58-67 oil. On February 28, the US struck Iran. Brent is now $112. *Everything in this brief flows from that reversal.*

Derived from the Kenya 2026 Economic Outlook | Econsult Africa Sector Intelligence Series

Contents

Section 1: Macro Context in 60 Seconds

This brief requires a preamble that no other brief in this series needs. **The single most important assumption in the entire Kenya 2026 Economic Outlook has been invalidated.**

The Outlook, finalised in February 2026, identified falling oil prices as "one of the strongest external tailwinds supporting the fragile stabilisation thesis." Brent crude averaged $69/bbl in 2025 and was trading at approximately $67 when the Outlook was completed. The EIA projected $58/bbl for 2026, J.P. Morgan $60/bbl, the World Bank $60/bbl, Goldman Sachs mid-$50s. At those levels, the Outlook projected $300-400 million in fuel import bill savings, a 0.3-0.5 percentage point disinflationary impulse, current account support, and reduced fiscal pressure from fuel subsidies (Econsult Africa, 2026).

On 28 February 2026, the United States and Israel launched coordinated strikes against Iran. The Strait of Hormuz, through which approximately 20% of global seaborne oil flows, has been effectively closed since 2 March. As of 27 March 2026, **Brent crude closed at $112.57 per barrel**, up 68% from the $67 level when the Outlook was written (Trading Economics, 2026; Techi, 2026). The EIA's revised March 2026 STEO now projects Brent remaining above $95 for the next two months, falling to $70 by Q4 2026 only if the Hormuz situation resolves (EIA, 2026). Goldman Sachs estimates a $14-18 per barrel geopolitical risk premium (FXOpen, 2026).

Kenya has not yet felt the full impact. EPRA froze pump prices for the March 15 to April 14 review period at KSh 178.28/L for petrol in Nairobi, because the pricing was based on February-priced cargoes received before the conflict (EPRA, 2026; Pulse Kenya, 2026). But the Murban crude benchmark that Kenya uses for pricing surged from KSh 9,861 per barrel on March 5 to KSh 11,915 per barrel on March 12 (CBK, 2026). The April EPRA review will be the first to price in the Hormuz disruption. Reports of fuel hoarding and localised shortages of approximately 20% have already emerged (AInvest, 2026). The price stabilisation fund, which lacks a formal governance framework according to the Auditor-General, is under acute pressure (AInvest, 2026).

The second story in this brief is better. Kenya generates approximately 90% of its electricity from renewable sources, primarily geothermal, hydro, and wind (ITA, 2026; KenGen, 2026). The oil shock hits transport and manufacturing, but it does **not** directly hit electricity costs. This structural insulation is Kenya's most underappreciated economic asset. The third story is construction: +6.7% growth in Q3 2025, cement consumption up 16.2%, credit to construction surging 52.9%, all driven by pre-election infrastructure spending that is projected to accelerate through mid-2027 (Econsult Africa, 2026).

> *This brief draws primarily on the Kenya 2026 Economic Outlook by Econsult Africa, supplemented by publicly available data through March 29, 2026. The Outlook's oil price assumptions have been materially overtaken by events since February 28, 2026. This brief identifies where the Outlook's analysis remains valid and where it requires revision.*

For the full macroeconomic analysis, see the Kenya 2026 Economic Outlook (https://econsult.africa/kenya-2026).

Section 2: Sector Performance and Trajectory

The Oil Shock: A Tailwind Becomes a Headwind

The Outlook's oil chapter, titled "Oil: The Bearish Structural Shift," identified structural oversupply as the dominant dynamic: OPEC+ unwinding production cuts at 411,000 bpd monthly, non-OPEC supply expanding, global demand growth below 1 million bpd, EV transition accelerating (Econsult Africa, 2026). All of that structural analysis remains valid. What changed is geopolitics. The Strait of Hormuz closure disrupted approximately 17.8 million barrels per day of transit, Iran began operating a yuan-based toll system for allied vessels, and Iraq declared force majeure on foreign-operated oilfields (Techi, 2026; EIA, 2026). Brent spiked from $72 to $95 within 72 hours, breached $100 by Day 10, peaked at $113.40 on March 19, and has since settled around $101-112 as Trump's diplomatic pause creates uncertainty (FXOpen, 2026; MEI, 2026).

For Kenya, the transmission is straightforward but delayed. The country imports 100% of its petroleum in refined form, priced against international benchmarks in US dollars. EPRA's monthly pricing mechanism creates a 30-45 day lag. The March 15 to April 14 pricing cycle reflects February-priced cargoes, so pump prices held at KSh 178.28 for petrol (EPRA, 2026). The April review, covering March-priced cargoes, will be the reckoning. At $100+ Brent and a KES at 130, a KSh 15-30 per litre increase is plausible unless the price stabilisation fund absorbs the difference, which the Auditor-General has flagged lacks a governance framework (AInvest, 2026). If Brent remains above $95 through Q2 as the EIA projects, the cumulative fiscal cost of stabilisation could reach KSh 30-50 billion, directly competing with the infrastructure spending the construction boom depends on.

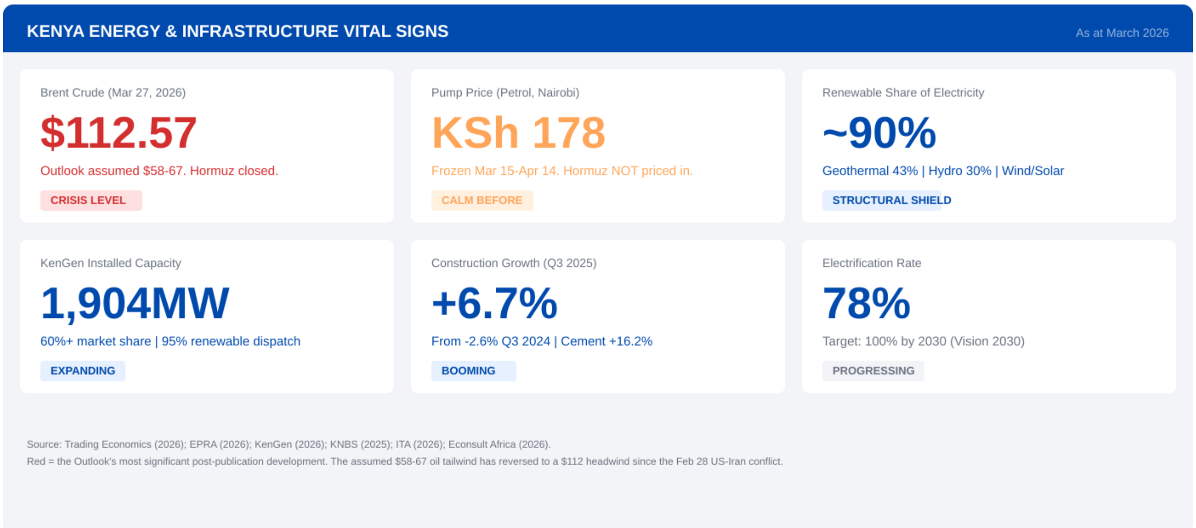

Figure 1: Energy & Infrastructure Vital Signs Dashboard, March 2026. The red indicator (Brent at $112.57) is the most consequential post-Outlook development across all eight briefs. Orange indicator (pump prices) reflects the calm-before-the-storm: February-priced cargoes have insulated consumers so far.

The Structural Shield: Kenya's 90% Renewable Grid

Here is the counterpoint that prevents the oil shock from becoming an economic crisis. KenGen, Kenya's leading power producer with 1,904MW of installed capacity and 60%+ market share, dispatches 95% of its electricity from renewable sources: geothermal (754MW), hydro (826MW), and wind (26MW) (KenGen, 2026; African Financials, 2025). Kenya is

Africa's number one and the world's seventh-largest geothermal producer. Approximately 90% of total national electricity comes from renewable sources (ITA, 2026). The oil shock hits transport and manufacturing input costs. It does not hit electricity generation costs, which are set by long-term PPAs with KenGen and independent power producers.

KenGen is accelerating its expansion. The Olkaria I project (63MW new geothermal capacity) is at 70% completion, with the first turbine expected to commission by June 2026 (Global Renewable News, 2026). The $1.8 billion Olkaria expansion plan will add wells connected to existing and new geothermal plants over five years, funded by the World Bank, EIB, AfDB, and JICA (ITA, 2026). The 42.5MW Seven Forks Solar PV plant is under development as part of KenGen's 253MW near-term renewable pipeline (PVknowhow, 2026). Kenya has secured $1.8 billion in loans for 14 projects spanning geothermal energy and grid expansion (PVknowhow, 2026). The G2G 2034 Strategy targets 1,500MW of new renewable capacity and 500MWh of energy storage (KenGen, 2026). The Green Energy Park at Olkaria, gazetted as a Special Economic Zone, offers industrial tenants geothermal-powered operations at globally competitive energy costs (African Financials, 2025).

The Construction Boom: Cyclical but Real

Construction rebounded 6.7% in Q3 2025 from a 2.6% contraction in Q3 2024, powered by a 16.2% surge in cement consumption and resumed government road works (Econsult Africa, 2026). Credit to construction surged 52.9% year-on-year to KSh 195.3 billion from KSh 129.2 billion (Econsult Africa, 2026). Affordable Housing registrations exceeded 720,000. The FY2026/27 budget is expected to front-load infrastructure spending: roads, housing, AFCON stadiums, and county-level projects all tied to the August 2027 election timeline. This is an explicitly cyclical opportunity. Pre-election governments in Kenya consistently accelerate infrastructure execution to demonstrate visible delivery. The pattern reverses post-election as new administrations review contracts, accumulate pending bills, and redirect spending. **The construction credit surge has a built-in exit date: August 2027.**

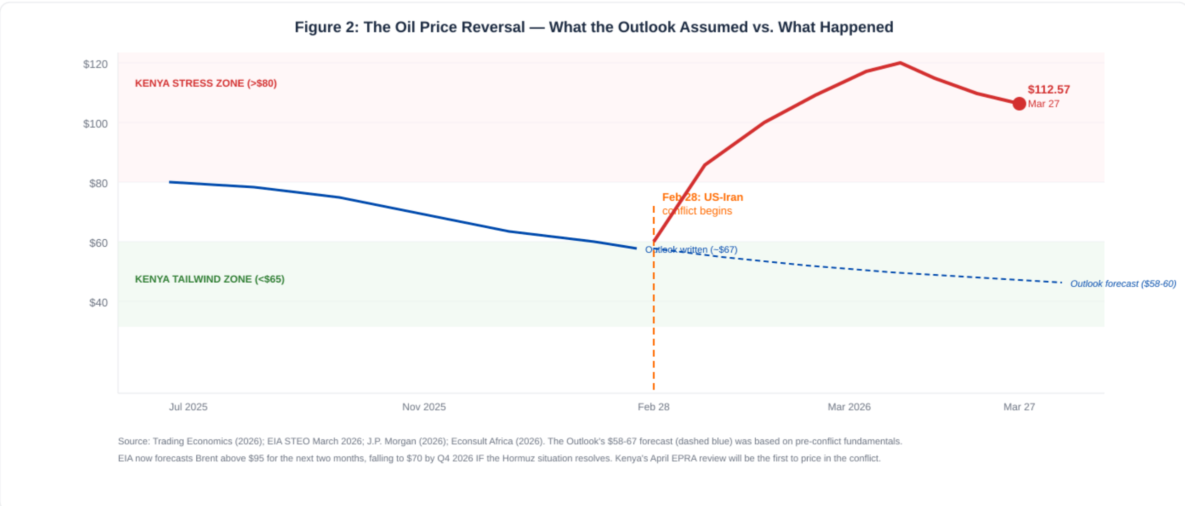

Figure 2: The Oil Price Reversal. The dashed blue line shows the Outlook's forecast path ($58-60/bbl). The solid red line shows what actually happened after February 28. The gap between the two lines represents the reversal of the Outlook's most favourable external assumption.

Section 3: Policy and Regulatory Environment

EPRA's Pricing Mechanism: Structured Stability with a Ticking Clock

EPRA calculates maximum retail fuel prices monthly, incorporating landed cost, storage and distribution, taxes and levies, and regulated margins. The mechanism creates stability: consumers are insulated from daily price swings. But it also creates a lag: the current KSh 178.28 per litre petrol price reflects February costs, not March's $100+ Brent reality (EPRA, 2026; Pulse Kenya, 2026). The price stabilisation fund has been absorbing the gap, but at growing fiscal cost. The total stabilisation spending has reached approximately KSh 13.18 billion, without the governance framework the Auditor-General says is needed (AInvest, 2026). If Brent remains elevated, the April or May EPRA review will force a choice: pass through the increase to consumers (politically explosive pre-election) or absorb it fiscally (competing with infrastructure spending).

KenGen's Expansion: The Long-Term Structural Answer

KenGen's G2G 2034 Strategy and the government's 5,000MW by 2030 target represent the structural response to import dependency. The partial lifting of the moratorium on new geothermal PPAs opens the door for additional private investment in generation (ITA, 2026). KenGen is expanding its geothermal consultancy portfolio internationally, with active or emerging projects in Ethiopia, Djibouti, Eswatini, Tanzania (Ngozi), and Bhutan, alongside a partnership with Toshiba ESS for operations and maintenance (KenGen, 2026). The Geothermal Training Centre trains specialists from across Africa and Asia, positioning Kenya as the global hub for geothermal expertise. The commercial and industrial solar segment is booming: Two Rivers Mall expanded its rooftop solar from 1.2MW to 3.2MW in early 2025, one of the largest in East Africa (PVknowhow, 2026).

The Fiscal Bind: Oil, Subsidies, and Infrastructure Spending

The oil shock creates a direct fiscal trade-off. Every shilling spent stabilising fuel prices is a shilling not spent on infrastructure. The FY2026/27 budget, expected in June, must simultaneously absorb potential oil-driven stabilisation costs, fund AFCON infrastructure, maintain pre-election road and housing projects, and service debt at 53% of revenue. The Outlook projects the government's Medium-Term Debt Management Strategy allocates 82% of borrowing from domestic sources (Econsult Africa, 2026). If the oil shock compresses fiscal space, the likeliest casualty is either infrastructure spending (politically costly pre-election) or fuel stabilisation (inflationary and politically explosive). **There is no comfortable path.**

Section 4: Risk Map

This sector contains the only risk across all eight briefs that has **already triggered**. Risk 1 is not a projection. It is happening now.

Risk 1: Oil Price Spike / Hormuz Disruption (Status: ACTIVE | Impact: High)

Brent at $112.57 as of March 27, up from $67 when the Outlook was written. Strait of Hormuz effectively closed since March 2. Kenya imports 100% of refined petroleum through Gulf-proximate routes. **Status:** This risk is active, not projected. **Resolution pathway:** EIA projects Brent falling to $70 by Q4 2026 IF conflict resolves and Hormuz reopens. Trump's 5-day diplomatic pause (March 23) is the first credible de-escalation signal. **Kenya transmission:** April EPRA review is the first to price in the conflict. Pump price increase of KSh 15-30/L is plausible. Inflation impact: 1-2 percentage points. Fiscal cost of stabilisation: KSh 30-50 billion annualised (Trading Economics, 2026; EIA, 2026; EPRA, 2026).

Risk 2: Post-Election Infrastructure Cliff (Probability: High | Impact: Medium-High)

Historical pattern: infrastructure spending collapses in post-election fiscal years. **Trigger:** August 2027 election. **Early warning:** Pending bills accumulating above KSh 200 billion; cement consumption decelerating in H1 2027. **Transmission:** Construction sector reverses from +6.7% to contraction; contractor cash flows collapse; banking NPLs in construction rise (Econsult Africa, 2026).

Risk 3: Drought / Hydro Generation Shortfall (Probability: Medium | Impact: Medium-High)

Kenya's 826MW of hydro capacity is rainfall-dependent. A failed March-May 2026 long rains season reduces hydro output, forcing reliance on expensive thermal backup and imports at precisely the moment oil prices are elevated. **Trigger:** Below-average March-May rainfall. **Early warning:** KMD rainfall forecasts; dam levels; KenGen hydro dispatch declining. **Transmission:** Higher electricity costs; KPLC financial pressure; potential load-shedding (Econsult Africa, 2026).

Risk 4: KPLC Financial Distress (Probability: Medium | Impact: Medium)

Kenya Power's financial health constrains the entire value chain. Elevated take-or-pay obligations, distribution losses, and debt servicing create chronic fiscal fragility. **Trigger:** KPLC unable to honour PPA payments to KenGen and IPPs. **Early warning:** KPLC quarterly results; government bailout discussions; tariff review petitions to EPRA.

Risk 5: Grid Capacity Constraints (Probability: Medium | Impact: Medium)

International bandwidth utilisation declined from 17,412 Gbps to 14,066 Gbps in Q3 2025, an unexpected reversal. Grid interconnection capacity constrains the integration of new renewable generation. KETRACO's transmission expansion is critical but capital-intensive. **Trigger:** Renewable generation exceeding grid absorption capacity; curtailment of geothermal or wind output. **Transmission:** Stranded renewable assets; delayed return on KenGen and IPP investments (Econsult Africa, 2026).

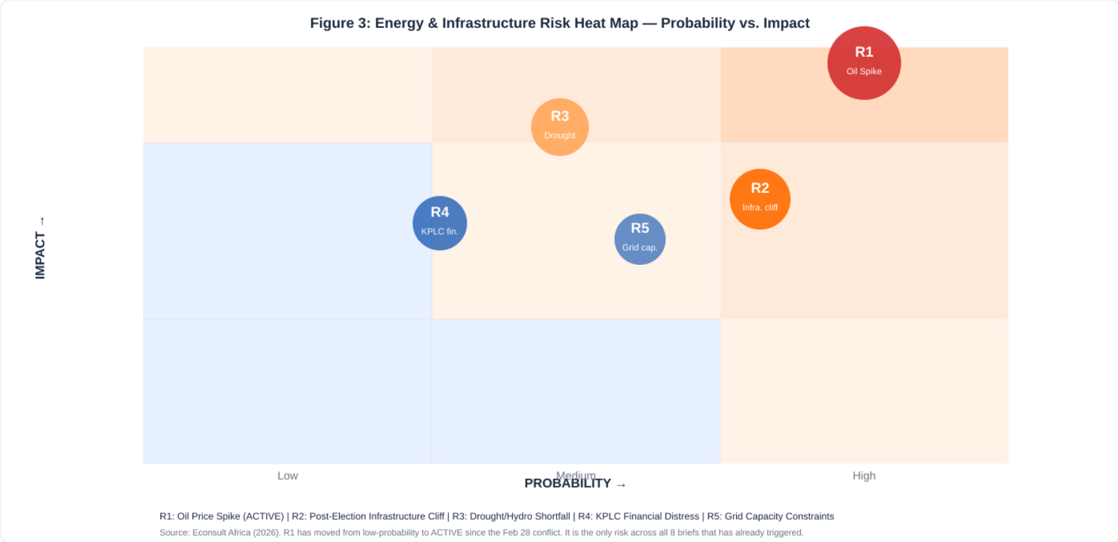

Figure 3: Energy & Infrastructure Risk Heat Map. R1 (Oil Price Spike) is the only risk across all eight briefs that sits in the high-probability, high-impact quadrant AND has already triggered. It moved from the Outlook's "tail risk" to "active crisis" on February 28, 2026.

Section 5: Opportunity Map

Opportunity 1: Geothermal Expansion (structural, 5-10 years)

Thesis: Kenya's 10,000MW geothermal potential is less than 10% exploited. KenGen's $1.8 billion Olkaria expansion, the G2G 2034 Strategy (1,500MW new renewable + 500MWh storage), and the partial lifting of the PPA moratorium create the pipeline. The oil shock makes the investment case stronger: every MW of geothermal capacity that displaces thermal generation reduces Kenya's vulnerability to exactly the kind of shock happening now. **Evidence:** Olkaria I (63MW) at 70% completion; Seven Forks Solar 42.5MW under development; KenGen consultancy expanding to 6+ countries; Green Energy Park SEZ gazetted. **Risk:** Exploration risk; capital intensity; KPLC offtake capacity. **Time horizon:** Structural (KenGen, 2026; ITA, 2026; Global Renewable News, 2026).

Opportunity 2: Renewable Energy Supply Chain (2-5 years)

Thesis: Africa's solar installations grew 54% in 2025. Kenya's commercial and industrial solar segment is booming. The EV transition is nascent but KenGen has launched pilot programmes. Battery energy storage, solar panel installation, and EV charging infrastructure represent a domestic supply chain opportunity. **Evidence:** Two Rivers Mall 3.2MW rooftop; Kenya securing $1.8 billion for grid expansion; C&I solar growing rapidly. **Risk:** Chinese import competition on solar panels; grid integration constraints. **Time horizon:** Medium-term (PVknowhow, 2026; KenGen, 2026).

Opportunity 3: Pre-Election Construction Boom (6-18 months, cyclical)

Thesis: Construction at +6.7%, cement +16.2%, credit +52.9%. Pre-election dynamics project acceleration through mid-2027: AFCON stadiums, Affordable Housing, roads, county projects. **Evidence:** 720,000+ Affordable Housing registrations; Talanta Stadium under construction; FY2026/27 budget expected to front-load spending. **Risk:** Post-election cliff; pending bills; oil-driven fiscal compression. **Time horizon: Exit before August 2027 is critical.** This is the most explicitly cyclical opportunity in the series (Econsult Africa, 2026).

Opportunity 4: KenGen Green Energy Park / Industrial SEZ (3-7 years)

Thesis: The Olkaria Green Energy Park, gazetted as a Special Economic Zone, offers industrial tenants geothermal-powered operations at electricity costs significantly below thermal alternatives. In a world of $100+ oil, the cost advantage of geothermal-powered manufacturing is amplified. **Evidence:** Fourth investor onboarded March 2026; global interest in nearshoring to renewable-powered zones; KenGen's geothermal expertise exportable. **Risk:** Infrastructure at Olkaria; water availability; distance from Nairobi port logistics. **Time horizon:** Medium to long-term (KenGen, 2026; African Financials, 2025).

Opportunity 5: Oil Import Diversification and Hedging (0-6 months, urgent)

Thesis: Kenya's 100% dependence on imported refined petroleum through Gulf-proximate routes is the structural vulnerability the Hormuz crisis has exposed. Diversification toward non-Gulf suppliers, establishment of strategic petroleum reserves, and hedging instruments are no longer theoretical recommendations. They are urgent operational necessities.

Evidence: The Hormuz closure; hoarding and 20% localised shortages; stabilisation fund under pressure. **Risk:** Diversification has higher per-unit costs; hedging requires financial sophistication; strategic reserves require capital investment. **Time horizon:** Immediate (AInvest, 2026; EPRA, 2026).

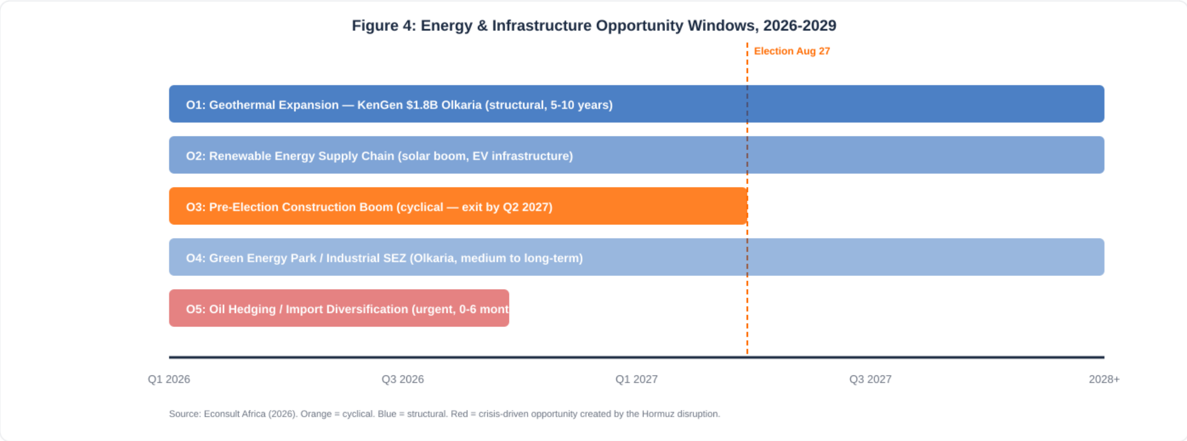

Figure 4: Opportunity Windows. The red bar (O5, oil import diversification) is a crisis-created opportunity that did not exist when the Outlook was written. The orange bar (O3, construction) has the sharpest exit trigger of any opportunity in the series.

Section 6: So What: Implications by Player Type

For Operators (energy companies, construction firms, fuel importers)

The oil shock is a 90-day planning horizon. Fuel importers should hedge April-June cargo costs immediately. Construction firms should accelerate pre-election project execution while fiscal space remains available; every month of delay increases the risk that oil-driven fiscal compression reduces infrastructure budgets. **KenGen is the structural winner:** every MW of geothermal that displaces thermal generation becomes more valuable in a $100+ oil world. IPPs with thermal PPAs face margin pressure.

For Investors (energy equity, infrastructure, construction)

KenGen equity is the most compelling structural play in Kenyan energy. 95% renewable dispatch, 5.2% dividend yield, G2G 2034 growth pipeline, and a Green Energy Park SEZ. The oil shock makes the investment thesis stronger, not weaker. **Construction-exposed investments require exit discipline:** the sector is booming now but has a built-in cliff in August 2027. **Avoid fuel import and distribution:** margin compression between EPRA-regulated pump prices and rising cargo costs creates a vice.

For Policymakers (Ministry of Energy, EPRA, National Treasury)

The April EPRA review is the most consequential fuel pricing decision in years. Pass through the increase and risk inflation and political backlash. Absorb it and drain the stabilisation fund while competing with infrastructure spending. **Accelerate the geothermal programme.** The Hormuz crisis demonstrates that Kenya's 90% renewable grid is a national security asset, not just an environmental achievement. Every dollar invested in geothermal capacity reduces structural vulnerability to exactly this kind of shock. **Establish a governance framework for the stabilisation fund** before the fiscal pressure becomes unmanageable.

For Development Partners (DFIs, World Bank, AfDB)

Kenya's renewable energy programme is the highest-return climate-and-security investment available. The Hormuz crisis converts the climate case into a national security case. $1.8 billion in existing KenGen financing should be accelerated, not slowed. Additional concessional financing for grid expansion (KETRACO), energy storage, and strategic petroleum reserves would address both the immediate crisis and the structural vulnerability. **Emergency technical assistance** for EPRA and the price stabilisation mechanism would help Kenya navigate the fiscal trade-offs the oil shock is creating.

Section 7: Key Indicators to Watch

Indicator	Current Value	Trend	Threshold	Source	Freq.
Brent crude oil	$112.57 (Mar 27)	▲ CRISIS	Sustained >$95: emergency	Trading Econ.	Daily
EPRA pump price (petrol)	KSh 178.28 (frozen)	Frozen	Apr review: +KSh 15-30	EPRA	Monthly
Stabilisation fund balance	Under pressure	▼ Depleting	Exhaustion	Nat. Treasury	Monthly
KES/USD	130.0 (Mar 26)	▲ Slight weak.	Breach 135 (oil-driven)	CBK	Daily
Construction growth	6.7% (Q3 2025)	▲ Booming	Deceleration below 3%	KNBS	Quarterly
Cement consumption	16.2% YoY	▲ Strong	Decline for 2 months	KNBS	Monthly
KenGen Olkaria I progress	70% complete	▲ On track	Behind schedule in Q2	KenGen	Quarterly
Hydro dam levels	Normal/high	↔ Monitoring	Below 60% capacity	KenGen	Weekly
Food CPI (oil pass-through)	7.3% (Feb 26)	↔ Sticky	Exceeds 10%	KNBS	Monthly
Hormuz shipping status	Effectively closed	▼ Crisis	Reopening = de-escalation	Reuters/EIA	Daily

Figure 5: Energy & Infrastructure Under Three Macro Scenarios (Remainder of 2026)

SCENARIO	OIL PRICE	PUMP PRICE	CONSTRUCTION	SECTOR VERDICT
UPSIDE Hormuz reopens Q2 Prob: 20-25%	**<$75 by Q3**	**Stable/falls** Oil tailwind returns	**7-8%** Pre-election spending sustained	ACCELERATE
BASELINE Hormuz partly reopens Prob: 45-50%	**$80-95**	**+KSh 10-20/L** Apr-May EPRA hike	**5-6%** Oil costs slow momentum	MIXED
DOWNSIDE Hormuz closed 3+ months Prob: 25-30%	**>$100 sustained**	**+KSh 30-50/L** Stabilisation fund exhausted	**<3%** Input costs crush margins	STAGFLATION

Source: Econsult Africa (2026); EIA STEO March 2026; Trading Economics (2026). These are forward-looking projections. The downside probability is elevated relative to other sectors because the trigger (Hormuz closure) has already occurred.

Figure 5: Forward-looking scenario projections for the remainder of 2026. The downside probability (25-30%) is elevated relative to other sectors because the trigger (Hormuz closure) has already occurred. Resolution timing determines which scenario plays out.

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Methodology

This brief is derived from the Kenya 2026 Economic Outlook, a comprehensive macroeconomic assessment by Econsult Africa, supplemented by publicly available data through March 2026. All sources are cited in APA 7th edition format. All 2026 sector-level projections remain forward-looking assessments as at the date of publication.

Primary source: Econsult Africa. (2026). Kenya 2026 Economic Outlook. Econsult Africa. https://https://econsult.africa/intelligence-marketplace

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